# Text 1

**第 1 段**

If you were to examine the birth certificates of every soccer player in 2006's World Cup tournament, you would most likely find a noteworthy quirk: elite soccer players are more likely to have been born in the earlier months of the year than in the later months. If you then examined the European national youth teams that feed the World Cup and professional ranks, you would find this strange phenomenon to be even more pronounced.

**直译：**如果你查看 2006 年世界杯每名足球运动员的出生证明，很可能发现一个值得注意的奇特现象：优秀球员更可能出生在一年较早的月份，而不是较晚的月份。如果再考察那些向世界杯和职业队伍输送球员的欧洲国家青年队，你会发现这种奇怪现象更加明显。

**第 2 段**

What might account for this strange phenomenon? Here are a few guesses: a) certain astrological signs confer superior soccer skills; b) winter-born babies tend to have higher oxygen capacity, which increases soccer stamina; c) soccer-mad parents are more likely to conceive children in springtime, at the annual peak of soccer mania; d) none of the above.

**直译：**什么能够解释这一现象呢？这里有几种猜测：一，某些星座赋予人更高超的足球技巧；二，冬天出生的婴儿往往有更强的摄氧能力，从而增强踢球的耐力；三，痴迷足球的父母更可能在春天受孕，因为那时是一年中足球热潮的高峰；四，以上皆非。

**第 3 段**

Anders Ericsson, a 58-year-old psychology professor at Florida State University, says he believes strongly in "none of the above." Ericsson grew up in Sweden, and studied nuclear engineering until he realized he would have more opportunity to conduct his own research if he switched to psychology. His first experiment, nearly 30 years ago, involved memory: training a person to hear and then repeat a random series of numbers. "With the first subject, after about 20 hours of training, his digit span had risen from 7 to 20," Ericsson recalls. "He kept improving, and after about 200 hours of training he had risen to over 80 numbers."

**直译：**佛罗里达州立大学 58 岁的心理学教授安德斯·埃里克森说，他坚定地相信"以上皆非"。埃里克森在瑞典长大，原先学习核工程，后来意识到转学心理学会使他有更多机会开展自己的研究。他近三十年前的第一个实验涉及记忆：训练一个人听一串随机数字，然后复述。埃里克森回忆："第一个受试者经过约 20 小时训练，数字记忆广度从 7 提高到 20。他继续进步；训练约 200 小时后，已经提高到 80 多个数字。"

**第 4 段**

This success, coupled with later research showing that memory itself is not genetically determined, led Ericsson to conclude that the act of memorizing is more of a cognitive exercise than an intuitive one. In other words, whatever inborn differences two people may exhibit in their abilities to memorize, those differences are swamped by how well each person "encodes" the information. And the best way to learn how to encode information meaningfully, Ericsson determined, was a process known as deliberate practice. Deliberate practice entails more than simply repeating a task. Rather, it involves setting specific goals, obtaining immediate feedback and concentrating as much on technique as on outcome.

**直译：**这一成功，加上后来表明记忆本身并非由遗传决定的研究，使埃里克森得出结论：记忆活动与其说是直觉活动，不如说是认知训练。换言之，无论两个人在记忆能力上表现出何种先天差异，各自对信息“编码”的好坏都会压倒这些差异。埃里克森认定，学习有意义地编码信息的最佳方法，是一种称为刻意练习的过程。刻意练习不只是重复某项任务，而是涉及设定具体目标、获得即时反馈，以及像关注结果一样关注技术。

**第 5 段**

Ericsson and his colleagues have thus taken to studying expert performers in a wide range of pursuits, including soccer. They gather all the data they can, not just performance statistics and biographical details but also the results of their own laboratory experiments with high achievers. Their work makes a rather startling assertion: the trait we commonly call talent is highly overrated. Or, put another way, expert performers — whether in memory or surgery, ballet or computer programming—are nearly always made, not born.

**直译：**因此，埃里克森及其同事开始研究包括足球在内的广泛领域的高水平表现者。他们搜集一切能够获得的数据，不只是成绩统计与个人经历细节，还包括自己针对高成就者开展的实验室实验结果。他们的工作提出了一个相当惊人的论断：我们通常称为天赋的特质，被大大高估了。换句话说，无论是在记忆还是外科手术、芭蕾还是计算机编程方面，杰出表现者几乎总是后天培养出来的，而不是天生的。

**篇章简析**

主旨：通过记忆训练研究，文章突出刻意练习的作用，质疑对天赋的过度归因。出生月份现象只是引入，所附节选未进一步完整解释其机制。第 4、5 段的遗传与天赋判断属于埃里克森研究立场；more ... than ... 表“与其说……不如说……”。

# Text 2

**第 1 段**

For the past several years, the Sunday newspaper supplement Parade has featured a column called "Ask Marilyn." People are invited to query Marilyn vos Savant, who at age 10 had tested at a mental level of someone about 23 years old; that gave her an IQ of 228 — the highest score ever recorded. IQ tests ask you to complete verbal and visual analogies, to envision paper after it has been folded and cut, and to deduce numerical sequences, among other similar tasks. So it is a bit confusing when vos Savant fields such queries from the average Joe (whose IQ is 100) as, What's the difference between love and fondness? Or what is the nature of luck and coincidence? It's not obvious how the capacity to visualize objects and to figure out numerical patterns suits one to answer questions that have eluded some of the best poets and philosophers.

**直译：**过去几年，周日报纸增刊《Parade》开设了一个名叫 " 问玛丽莲 " 的专栏。人们可以向玛丽莲 · 沃斯 · 萨凡特提问；她在 10 岁时测出的智力水平相当于约 23 岁的人，因此智商达到 228，是曾有记录的最高分。智商测验要求你完成语言与图形类比，想象纸张折叠并剪切后的形状，推导数字序列，以及其他类似任务。因此，当萨凡特回答智商为 100 的普通人提出的问题，例如爱与喜欢有什么区别，或运气与巧合的本质是什么时，就有些令人困惑。能够在脑中想象物体、推算数字规律，如何使人适于回答那些连最优秀的诗人和哲学家也未能解决的问题，并不清楚。

**第 2 段**

Clearly, intelligence encompasses more than a score on a test. Just what does it mean to be smart? How much of intelligence can be specified, and how much can we learn about it from neurology, genetics, computer science and other fields?

**直译：**显然，智力所包含的，不只是一次测验的分数。聪明究竟是什么意思？智力有多少能够被明确描述？通过神经学、遗传学、计算机科学及其他领域，我们又能了解它多少？

**第 3 段**

The defining term of intelligence in humans still seems to be the IQ score, even though IQ tests are not given as often as they used to be. The test comes primarily in two forms: the Stanford-Binet Intelligence Scale and the Wechsler Intelligence Scales (both come in adult and children's version). Generally costing several hundred dollars, they are usually given only by psychologists, although variations of them populate bookstores and the World Wide Web. Superhigh scores like vos Savant's are no longer possible, because scoring is now based on a statistical population distribution among age peers, rather than simply dividing the mental age by the chronological age and multiplying by 100. Other standardized tests, such as the Scholastic Assessment Test (SAT) and the Graduate Record Exam (GRE), capture the main aspects of IQ tests.

**直译：**衡量人类智力的决定性指标似乎仍是智商分数，尽管智商测验已不像过去那样经常使用。测验主要有两种形式：斯坦福 — 比奈智力量表和韦克斯勒智力量表，两者都有成人版和儿童版。它们一般费用为数百美元，通常只由心理学家施测，尽管各种变体充斥书店和万维网。像萨凡特那样超高的分数如今已不再可能，因为计分现在依据同龄群体的统计分布，而不是简单地用智力年龄除以实际年龄，再乘 100。SAT 和 GRE 等其他标准化测验，也涵盖智商测验的主要方面。

**第 4 段**

Such standardized tests may not assess all the important elements necessary to succeed in school and in life, argues Robert J. Sternberg. In his article "How Intelligent Is Intelligence Testing?", Sternberg notes that traditional tests best assess analytical and verbal skills but fail to measure creativity and practical knowledge, components also critical to problem solving and life success. Moreover, IQ tests do not necessarily predict so well once populations or situations change. Research has found that IQ predicted leadership skills when the tests were given under low-stress conditions, but under high-stress conditions, IQ was negatively correlated with leadership — that is, it predicted the opposite. Anyone who has toiled through SAT will testify that test-taking skill also matters, whether it's knowing when to guess or what questions to skip.

**直译：**罗伯特·J. 斯腾伯格认为，这种标准化测验未必能评估在学校和生活中成功所必需的全部重要要素。在《智力测验究竟有多“聪明”?》一文中，他指出，传统测验最擅长评估分析与语言技能，却不能衡量创造力和实践知识，而这些同样是解决问题和取得人生成功的关键组成部分。此外，一旦人群或情境变化，智商测验就未必仍有那么好的预测能力。研究发现，在低压力条件下施测时，智商能预测领导技能；但在高压力条件下，智商与领导能力呈负相关，也就是说，预测方向相反。任何艰难应对过 SAT 的人都会证明，应试技能也很重要，例如知道何时该猜，或哪些题该跳过。

**篇章简析**

主旨：智商分数只衡量智力的一部分，预测能力还受情境和应试技巧影响。第 1 段以高智商专栏引出“测验技能能否等同一般智慧”的疑问；第 4 段集中呈现局限。文中智商计分和测验描述按历史原文理解。

# Text 3

**第 1 段**

During the past generation, the American middle-class family that once could count on hard work and fair play to keep itself financially secure has been transformed by economic risk and new realities. Now a pink slip, a bad diagnosis, or a disappearing spouse can reduce a family from solidly middle class to newly poor in a few months.

**直译：**在过去一代人的时间里，曾经可以依靠勤奋工作和公平行事来保持经济稳定的美国中产家庭，已被经济风险和新的现实改变。如今，一纸解雇通知、一项严重的诊断，或配偶的离去，就能在几个月内，使一个稳稳处于中产阶层的家庭沦为新贫家庭。

**第 2 段**

In just one generation, millions of mothers have gone to work, transforming basic family economics. Scholars, policymakers, and critics of all stripes have debated the social implications of these changes, but few have looked at the side effect: family risk has risen as well. Today's families have budgeted to the limits of their new two-paycheck status. As a result, they have lost the parachute they once had in times of financial setback - a back-up earner (usually Mom) who could go into the workforce if the primary earner got laid off or fell sick. This "added-worker effect" could support the safety net offered by unemployment insurance or disability insurance to help families weather bad times. But today, a disruption to family fortunes can no longer be made up with extra income from an otherwise-stay-at-home partner.

**直译：**仅仅一代人时间，数百万母亲走向工作岗位，改变了家庭经济的基本结构。学者、政策制定者和各种立场的评论家，已经讨论了这些变化的社会影响，却很少有人考察其副作用：家庭风险也增加了。如今的家庭，预算已把新获得的双薪收入用到极限。因此，它们失去了过去经济受挫时拥有的降落伞，即一名后备挣钱者，通常是母亲；当主要挣钱者被解雇或生病时，她可以进入劳动力市场。这种“新增劳动者效应”可以补充失业保险或残疾保险提供的安全网，帮助家庭渡过艰难时期。但今天，家庭经济遭受冲击时，已经无法再用原本留在家中的伴侣所带来的额外收入弥补。

**第 3 段**

During the same period, families have been asked to absorb much more risk in their retirement income. Steelworkers, airline employees, and now those in the auto industry are joining millions of families who must worry about interest rates, stock market fluctuation, and the harsh reality that they may outlive their retirement money. For much of the past year, President Bush campaigned to move Social Security to a savings-account model, with retirees trading much or all of their guaranteed payments for payments depending on investment returns. For younger families, the picture is not any better. Both the absolute cost of healthcare and the share of it borne by families have risen — and newly fashionable health-savings plans are spreading from legislative halls to Wal-Mart workers, with much higher deductibles and a large new dose of investment risk for families' future healthcare. Even demographics are working against the middle class family, as the odds of having a weak elderly parent— and all the attendant need for physical and financial assistance — have jumped eightfold in just one generation.

**直译：**同一时期，家庭还被要求承担更多退休收入风险。钢铁工人、航空公司员工，如今还有汽车行业员工，正加入数百万家庭的行列：他们必须担忧利率、股市波动，以及自己可能活到退休储蓄已经耗尽这一严酷现实。在过去一年中的大部分时间里，布什总统一直推动把社会保障制度转向储蓄账户模式，让退休者用大部分或全部有保证的给付，换取依赖投资回报的给付。对较年轻家庭，情形也没有更好。医疗费用的绝对数额和由家庭承担的份额都已上升；新近流行的健康储蓄计划正从立法机构扩展到沃尔玛员工，带来高得多的免赔额，并为家庭未来医疗增添大量投资风险。就连人口结构也对中产家庭不利：在仅仅一代人的时间里，有一位体弱的高龄父亲或母亲，并由此需要提供身体照料与经济援助的可能性，已经猛增至八倍。

**第 4 段**

From the middle-class family perspective, much of this, understandably, looks far less like an opportunity to exercise more financial responsibility, and a good deal more like a frightening acceleration of the wholesale shift of financial risk onto their already overburdened shoulders. The financial fallout has begun, and the political fallout may not be far behind.

**直译：**从中产家庭的角度看，可以理解，上述许多变化看起来远不像是一个承担更多财务责任的机会，而更像是把经济风险全面转嫁到他们早已不堪重负的肩上，而且这种转嫁正在以令人恐惧的速度加快。经济后果已经开始显现，政治后果或许也不会太远。

**篇章简析**

主旨：双薪并不必然增强家庭抵御风险的能力；备用劳动力减少，加上养老、医疗与赡养负担，使风险向家庭转移。第 2 段解释备用收入渠道丧失；第 3 段并列三类压力。less like ... more like ... 明确作者对“财务责任”说法的质疑。

# Text 4

**第 1 段**

It never rains but it pours. Just as bosses and boards have finally sorted out their worst accounting and compliance troubles, and improved their feeble corporation governance, a new problem threatens to earn them — especially in America — the sort of nasty headlines that inevitably lead to heads rolling in the executive suite: data insecurity. Left, until now, to odd, low-level IT staff to put right, and seen as a concern only of data-rich industries such as banking, telecoms and air travel, information protection is now high on the boss's agenda in businesses of every variety.

**直译：**祸不单行。老板和董事会刚刚解决最严重的会计与合规问题，改善了薄弱的公司治理，一个新问题又可能给他们，尤其是美国企业，招来那种难看的头条新闻，而这样的新闻不可避免地会导致高管被撤换：数据不安全。直到现在，信息保护还一直被交给少数低层 IT 员工处理，并被看作只是银行、电信、航空等数据密集行业的事务；如今，它已经成为各类企业老板议程上的要事。

**第 2 段**

Several massive leakages of customer and employee data this year — from organizations as diverse as Time Warner, the American defense contractor Science Applications International Corp and even the University of California, Berkeley — have left managers hurriedly peering into their intricate IT systems and business processes in search of potential vulnerabilities.

**直译：**今年发生了几次客户与员工数据的大规模泄露，涉及时代华纳、美国国防承包商科学应用国际公司，甚至加利福尼亚大学伯克利分校等性质迥异的机构。这些事件使管理者匆忙审视复杂的 IT 系统与业务流程，寻找潜在漏洞。

**第 3 段**

"Data is becoming an asset which needs to be guarded as much as any other asset," says Haim Mendelson of Stanford University's business school. "The ability to guard customer data is the key to market value, which the board is responsible for on behalf of shareholders". Indeed, just as there is the concept of Generally Accepted Accounting Principles (GAAP), perhaps it is time for GASP, Generally Accepted Security Practices, suggested Eli Noam of New York's Columbia Business School. "Setting the proper investment level for security, redundancy, and recovery is a management issue, not a technical one," he says.

**直译：**斯坦福大学商学院的海姆·门德尔松说："数据正成为一种资产，需要像其他任何资产一样受到保护。保护客户数据的能力，是市场价值的关键，而董事会有责任代表股东维护市场价值。"的确，正如有"公认会计原则"这一概念一样，纽约哥伦比亚商学院的伊莱·诺姆建议，也许现在该有"公认安全规范"了。他说："为安全、冗余和恢复设定适当的投资水平，是一个管理问题，而不是技术问题。"

**第 4 段**

The mystery is that this should come as a surprise to any boss. Surely it should be obvious to the dimmest executive that trust, that most valuable of economic assets, is easily destroyed and hugely expensive to restore — and that few things are more likely to destroy trust than a company letting sensitive personal data get into the wrong hands.

**直译：**令人费解的是，任何老板竟然会对此感到意外。即使最迟钝的高管，也理应明白，信任是最宝贵的经济资产，极易遭到破坏，而恢复它的代价极高；而且，几乎没有什么比公司让敏感个人数据落入不该掌握它们的人手中，更容易摧毁信任。

**第 5 段**

The current state of affairs may have been encouraged — though not justified — by the lack of legal penalty (in America, but not Europe) for data leakage. Until California recently passed a law, American firms did not have to tell anyone, even the victim, when data went astray. That may change fast: lots of proposed data-security legislation is now doing the rounds in Washington, D.C. Meanwhile, the theft of information about some 40 million credit-card accounts in America, disclosed on June 17, overshadowed a hugely important decision a day earlier by America's Federal Trade Commission (FTC) that puts corporate America on notice that regulators will act if firms fail to provide adequate data security.

**直译：**当前局面可能受到数据泄露缺乏法律惩罚的助长，尽管这并不能使它变得正当；这种情况存在于美国，而非欧洲。直到加利福尼亚州最近通过一项法律之前，美国企业的数据出了问题，也不必告知任何人，甚至不必告知受害者。这种情况可能很快改变：许多数据安全立法提案正在华盛顿流转。与此同时，6 月 17 日披露的美国约 4000 万信用卡账户信息失窃案，掩盖了前一天美国联邦贸易委员会一项极其重要的决定。该决定向美国企业界发出明确警告：如果企业不能提供充分的数据安全保障，监管者就会采取行动。

**篇章简析**

主旨：数据安全已成为董事会和高管必须承担的管理责任，既关系信任，也面临监管压力。第 3 段不是否认技术工作，而是强调投资与责任不能只下放给技术人员。第 5 段 encouraged 与 justified 分开：缺少惩罚可解释现象，不能为其辩护。法律状况按历史文章叙述。

整理说明：依据所附年度试卷提取 Text 1–Text 4；每段英文后接中文直译。已修复明显断词、粘连、错字和标点损坏。文中数据、事件及观点均置于原文章的历史语境中理解。篇章简析为本次整理所加。